

The Righteous Branch is Righteous for Us

Jeremiah 33:14-16

'The days are coming,' declares the LORD, 'when I will fulfill the good promise I made to the people of Israel and Judah. "In those days and at that time I will make a righteous Branch sprout from David's line; he will do what is just and right in the land. In those days Judah will be saved and Jerusalem will live in safety. This is the name by which it will be called: The LORD Our Righteous Savior.'

In the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit. Amen.

When Jesus was born, Israel hadn't had a king for a long time. There used to be kings in Israel and Judah, but that had been hundreds of years before. Now, the Romans were in control of the territory, and even though a guy named Herod had the title of "king," he wasn't a real king. He didn't have any real power. The "glory" days of Israel and Judah's kingdoms were long gone. David's royal line was cut off. At one point in history, you could have described David's kingdom as a beautiful, thriving tree, but eventually, it was nothing but a dead, rotting stump. Hoping that stump would somehow once again spring to life and become a great tree again would be a waste of time and energy.

But God made a promise that David's kingdom would last forever. He promised that a king would come and rule over God's people for eternity. He promised that his kingdom would be an eternal kingdom, and his people would be saved. For a while, this promise looked like nothing but a dead, lifeless stump, just like David's royal family line. But all of a sudden, a branch shot up from that stump—a green, living branch that would grow and thrive and become more and more glorious until it was a tree that was even bigger and grander than anything David's kingdom had looked like. God turned that dead, lifeless stump into a kingdom that will last forever with a king that will reign forever. You know his name. His name is Jesus!

In this prophecy, Jeremiah doesn't call him Jesus, but he calls him "The LORD Our Righteous Savior." You could even say his name is "The LORD Our Righteousness." He is perfect, he is holy, and most of all, he has come to save us. His kingdom extends way past Israel and Judah; his branches reach all across the world, covering and protecting everyone who believes in him. His branches now reach us! He is our Lord. He is our righteousness. He is our king. He is our Savior. Thank God for keeping his promise!

The questions below are to help families discuss this devotion. The questions are divided by age group as suggestions, but anyone could reflect on any of the questions as they desire.

Questions for the Younger Children

- What makes a good king?
- What makes Jesus such a good king?

Questions for Elementary Age Children

- Why would it be such a surprise to see a green branch growing out of a tree stump?
- Why is this green, living branch growing from a dead stump such a good picture of Jesus our righteous savior?

Questions for Middle School and Above

- Imagine you're living in Bethlehem in the year 1 BC. Your royal family has been powerless and glory-less for almost 600 years. How does that make you feel?
- Now imagine that you hear about the new King born in Bethlehem. What impact does that have on your life?

Closing Prayer:

God our Father, we thank and praise you for sending the righteous Branch, Jesus, to be our Lord and Savior. We pray that your kingdom extends further and further as more and more people believe in your glorious name. Amen.